Desert Rivers Analysis: by Lade Wosornu

Issues in the poem

This poem points out that there are a lot of life activities which go unnoticed as we go through the ups and downs of our daily lives. This poem seeks to encourage the reader to find hope and courage even in the most hopeless situation. We will go into some details in the poem but first let's go through this amazing poem.

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Desert Rivers

by Lade Wosornu

Deserts too have their rivers

Entombed from birth in earth

Waters mightier than Voltas

Lie hid from glare of sun

And winds that dry

Roofed not by sky

But rocks that do not always hold

These run their unwitnessed course

To their unwitnessed end. Without a sound

They gush into bowels of seas

Far, far away from unaided human eyes.

If you cannot see our tears

It does not mean we do not cry.

Some themes in the poem

1. There are values in people we sometimes count as valueless.

This means irrespective of one’s educational background, position or current situation, they cannot be counted as useless.

2. People have hidden talents. The fact that these talents are not seen does not mean they do not exist.

Line 12 and 13 clearly explain a this fact. The line reads, ” if you do not see our tears, it does not mean we do not cry.”

3. Poverty can hide/limit one’s potentials and abilities.

Eg line 1 and 2 quotes, ” Deserts too have their rivers Entombed from birth in earth.

“Entombed” here means covered/buried Therefore a person’s abilities can be covered right from birth and may even continue throughout the entire life of that individual.

4. Lack of support and motivation may kill/ hide one’s talents.

Sometimes we all need motivation, support and cheers from our families and loved one’s to help us reach our goals.

The “rocks” in line 7 of the poem relates to the people mentioned.

5. People may be hurting in the large society that we live in, but they may be suffering silently.

Literary devices in the poem

Oxymoron

1.”Desert Rivers” :These are two contradicting words that are closely held together.

Symbolism

1.Desert : Desert represents represents individuals assumed to have nothing good in them.

2. Rivers : Rivers symbolises one’s talents and potentials.

3. Rocks : Rocks represent people around us like our families, friends and the society.

4. Sun : The Sun symbolises witnesses, viewers or the society.

5. Sky : It symbolises nature

Rhymes

1.”Entombed from birth in earth” : Birth and earth have the same internal rhyme.

2. ”Dry and Sky” : Lines 5 and 6 have two last words as dry and sky which have the same tail end sounds as /ai/

Metaphor

1. “Bowels of seas” (Line 10). The sea has no bowels or belly. Bowels have been used metaphorically as the middle of the sea.

Repetition

1. Far , far away from unaided human eyes: ”Far” has been repeated twice on the same line

Alliteration

1. Far, far away from unaided human eyes: the two repeated words far and far have the same /f/ consonant sound in the beginning.

Simile

1. Waters mightier than Voltas (line 3) : There is a direct comparison between waters and rivers with the connecting word “than”

Form and Structure

Desert rivers is a one stanza poem with 13 lines which does not rhyme. We can therefore conclude it’s a “free verse.”

Some Questions and Answers on the Poem

1. What does the reference to the “Voltas” convey?

Ans: It Convey’s the setting of the poem

Note: Volta is a large river in Ghana

2. Complete this line : “if you do not see our tears”……

Ans: it does not mean we do not cry

3. Identify any three literary devices used in the poem.

Ans: Metaphor, Simile, Repetition

4. What happens far, far away from unaided human eyes?

Ans: The gushing of rivers into bowels of seas.

5. What literary device is found in “waters mightier than Voltas”?

Ans: Simile

6. How many lines are in the poem?

Ans: 13 lines

7. What can you say about, “these run their unwitnessed course to their unwitnessed end”

Ans: People exhibit unseen talents

8. How does the poet describe the underground water?

Ans: They move with urgency without a sound.

9. Find two places you can find rhymes

Ans: Line 2 and 3 (Dry and sky)

Ans: Line 2 (birth and earth)

10. Name one issue raised by the poem.

Ans: Sometimes people tend to focus on the outward appearances instead of inner qualities of people.

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